



▲ **Economist John Matthai** served as India's first minister of railways.

Indian economist John Matthai, while presenting the first Interim Railway Budget of independent India in November 1947, reflected on the many challenges they had been presented. Besides a truncated railway system, there was "depleted staff, lack of resources, the virtual breakdown of law and order, the large numbers of refugees – destitute and miserable but often very defiant and difficult – finally the wrath of the elements in the form of these unprecedented floods that have